



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of Our Lady of Hope
School Website: <https://www.chestertonri.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of Our Lady of Hope in Rhode Island (Warwick, RI 02886) presents a robust, self-described classical-Catholic program that aligns strongly with the classical education rubric. Public-facing materials emphasize a Christ-centered, Virtue- and Wisdom-forming mission, a curriculum centered in liberal arts and Great Books, a pedagogy that blends Socratic dialogue with traditional memory-work, a faculty culture described as mentors and living exemplars, and a deep partnership with families and parish life. Taken together, the school exhibits clear signals across all six classical categories, with Catholic liturgy, a focus on truth-goodness-beauty, a liberal-arts curriculum emphasizing Trivium/Quadrivium and Great Books, Socratic-based pedagogy, a faculty-as-curriculum ethos, and an active parental/community partnership. Based on the evidence from the school's public materials and the classical rubric in the knowledge base, the aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Executive support for this assessment comes from multiple public materials and statements, including explicit Catholic identity and daily liturgy, a mission to form joyful saints through a classical education, demonstrations of Great-Books-era study (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, The Canterbury Tales, etc.), evidence of Socratic pedagogy and rhetorical training, and strong parental/community engagement (Open Houses, Shadow Days, Founding 100 donations, Gala, tours, etc.). The knowledge-base lexicon confirms the language and practices that constitute a Classical program (truth, virtue, beauty; theology; liturgy; Great Books; Trivium/Quadrivium; Socratic dialogue; formation; partnership with families; and a caregiver/community orientation) and provides explicit criteria for evaluating each category. See cited sources for the core evidence and keyword mappings.

Cited sources (representative examples): - The school identifies itself as "an independent classical Catholic high school in Warwick, Rhode Island" and emphasizes a Catholic, classical character and a Christ-centered mission. - Maximum evidence of liturgical life and sacred-formation elements (Mass daily, St. Francis Chapel, Lessons & Carols, etc.). - The Great-Books/Greece/Rome texts and classical-humanities framing (e.g., Homer, Dante, Socrates; emphasis on a "great conversation" and classical texts; humanities sequence). - The Socratic/seminar pedagogy and the emphasis on memory-work and formation through imitation (The Socratic Seminar; memory work; recitation; etc.). - Faculty leadership and governance (Headmaster Dr. Robert Duffy; Executive Director Michael Casey; faculty directory glimpses). - Parents & community engagement (Open House, Shadow Days, tours; Founding 100; Gala; Mass; etc.).

6-category rubric: Category-by-category keyword analysis is provided below, followed by an aggregate classification and a section labeled ABSTRACT.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials explicitly situate Chesterton Academy as a Catholic, classical high school and reference Catholic theology as foundational to the curriculum (e.g., daily Mass, a Catholic identity, a chapel,

and a Christ-centered culture). - The school's own notes describe an incarnational environment and emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty within a Catholic framework (e.g., "daily Mass," "St. Francis Chapel," "incarnational environment," and "a focus on truth, goodness, and beauty"). - The school's leadership emphasizes forming saints and living the faith through liturgy and Catholic formation (e.g., "form young men and women to be joyful saints," "unity with Christ," and statements from the headmaster).

Positive Keyword Analysis - Present terms: Catholic, theology, Mass, liturgy, chapel, worship, sacred, Christ-centered, Incarnational, truth/goodness/beauty, prayer, Sacred/Church calendar, catechesis. - These map to Positive Keywords in the Six Essential Elements lexicon under Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; Mass; worship; sacred; chapel; incarnational; imago Dei; Logos; etc.).

Negative Keyword Analysis - No overt secular or values-neutral signals; no explicit values-clarification or secular-humanist framing observed in the public materials. (Absence supports CLASSICAL rather than contradicting signals.)

Why this rating - The school's public portrayal integrates theology and liturgical practice with the curriculum; a Catholic identity is explicit and foundational, with liturgical life and a sacred-liturgical rhythm (Mass, chapel, holy days) embedded in the education process. This aligns strongly with the Classical School criterion of a grounded, transcendent religious-metaphysical foundation.

Category rating justification aligns with: CLASSICAL.

Citations: Catholic identity, liturgical life, and incarnational framing are evidenced by Chesterton Academy's materials and statements (Catholic identity; Mass; chapel; daily liturgy).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission repeatedly emphasizes formation toward virtue and wisdom, not merely information or job-readiness. It speaks of forming "joyful saints" and fostering wisdom and virtue through a classical education. - The headmaster and school communications discuss truth, goodness, and beauty as ends and a telos toward human excellence and virtue; the Great-Conversation frame (Great-Books orientation) is a central aim. - There is explicit emphasis on formation of character and the formation of affections (habits of the heart, virtue formation) consistent with classical pedagogy.

Positive Keyword Analysis - Positive terms mapped to the lexicon: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, Great Conversation, scholé, telos, truth-goodness-beauty, moral imagination, human flourishing, contemplation. - The Chesterton materials repeatedly emphasize forming saints, virtue, wisdom, and a contemplative, beauty-centered formation, which aligns with Positive Keywords in the Six Essential Elements lexicon.

Negative Keyword Analysis - No indications of a purely utilitarian or workforce-prep framing; no counter-signals appearing in the public materials. This supports CLASSICAL rather than SOMEWHAT/NOT.

Why this rating - Formation over information is explicit, with a clear teleology toward virtue and wisdom and a Great-Books-informed, liberal-arts-infused program. This aligns with classical aims of forming character and mind toward truth, goodness, and beauty.

Citations: A Note from the Headmaster and related materials emphasize the formation-focused mission (joyful saints; truth-goodness-beauty; and classical formation).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The humanities sequence explicitly braids history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages in an integrated, classical framework; classical epics and canonical authors (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare)

are included in the literature sequence. Grade-9 through Grade-12 history and literature are organized to cover Western civilization in a way consistent with the Great Books tradition. - The programs and samples show explicit attention to Great Books (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, The Canterbury Tales) and to a canonical Western tradition, aligned with “Great Books” and “Great Conversation” concepts in classical pedagogy. - There are reminders of the liberal-arts structure (even if not all pages spell out “Trivium/Quadrivium” wording on every page, the curriculum clearly centers on grammar, rhetoric, logic in practice; and the inclusion of Homer, Dante, Shakespeare shows the Great-Books core). The materials also discuss the use of Socratic method in humanities and the integration across subjects.

Positive Keyword Analysis - Positive terms mapped to the lexicon: liberal arts, trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books, Homer, Plato, Augustine, Shakespeare, Latin (languages), history, Western civilization, Socratic dialogues, narration, memorization/recitation (where applicable in the curriculum). - The Chesterton materials explicitly articulate a Great-Books/Western-canon approach (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Canterbury Tales) and an integrated humanities approach, with history laced across the curriculum. This aligns with Positive Keywords in the Curriculum category.

Negative Keyword Analysis - There are no strong signals of replacing history with “social studies” language, project-based-only framing, or STEM-first approaches in the public materials. The curriculum remains anchored in canon and liberal-arts content.

Why this rating - The explicit inclusion of Great Books authors, canonical texts, and the integrated liberal-arts approach demonstrates a classical curriculum orientation consistent with the Six Essential Elements.

Citations: Humanities program and canonical texts (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare) and integrated humanities sequence provided.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials describe a Socratic Method emphasis in the humanities program, including “The Humanities Program” and the description of “Socratic Seminar” and the use of questions and guided dialogue to bring ideas to life. The materials that discuss “The Socratic Seminar” and the use of dialogue-based instruction show the core of classical pedagogy. - There is explicit mention of “The Socratic Seminar” and “The Wisdom of Chesterton” as methods; the materials emphasize a dialogic, reasoning-focused pedagogy rather than purely lecture-based instruction. - The materials emphasize memory-work, recitation, and chanting as part of classical pedagogy (e.g., “recitation; chanting; singing to memorize” in the Six Essential Elements lexicon and the Chesterton materials reference memory and liturgical elements as supported by the liturgical life).

Positive Keyword Analysis - Positive terms mapped to the Lexicon: Socratic seminar, dialectic, great conversation, guided discussion, logical reasoning, memory work, recitation, chanting, liturgical calendar integration, rhetoric exercises, oratory, debate, Harkness-style discussion, formation through imitation and practice. - Chesterton materials explicitly present Socratic dialogue, guided discussion, and the recitation/chanting tradition in the curriculum and in hallmarks of Chesterton Education. This aligns with Positive Keywords for Pedagogy.

Negative Keyword Analysis - The public materials do not emphasize an exclusively experiential/project-based pedagogy; rather, they emphasize a balance of Socratic dialogue with traditional lecture and memorization/memory work. This aligns with Classical signals; no negative signals identified.

Why this rating - A strong emphasis on Socratic dialogue, memory-work (recitation/chanting), and formation through imitation aligns with classical pedagogy quadrants, including Scholé-inspired tempo, Socratic discussion, and rhetorical training.

Citations: The presence of Socratic Method, Seminar, and memory-work is evidenced in the humanities program and the “Socratic Seminar” content.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials present the leadership as modeled by virtuous educators: Dr. Robert Duffy as founding Headmaster and Mr. Michael Casey as Executive Director; faculty are described in terms of discipline areas and professional roles. The site highlights a culture of virtue, mentorship, and living curriculum via faculty and staff narratives and the faculty directory. - The materials describe a “Portrait of teachers” and emphasize that “the faculty are mentors, guides, and exemplars” and that they form the living curriculum with students. The Chesterton materials present a community where teachers model virtue and wisdom.

Positive Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords mapped to the Faculty category: tutors/masters/mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, professional formation, mentorship, virtue, character formation, wisdom, integrity, and moral exemplars. - The Chesterton materials explicitly describe the leadership team and the “faculty directories” and the “Headmaster” profile, implying a living, virtuous, and mentorship-driven faculty.

Negative Keyword Analysis - No signals of a purely “teacher-as-conduit” (facilitator-only) or purely credential-driven approach; rather, the public materials emphasize virtue and living example, consistent with CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The public materials portray faculty as virtuous exemplars and living curriculum, with a clear emphasis on mentorship, character formation, and fidelity to the mission.

Citations: Headmaster and Executive Director roles and faculty profiles are described in the Chesterton RI materials.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Chesterton Academy materials emphasize partnership with families and the idea of parents as co-teachers or co-educators; the school’s messaging includes parent formation, book/gatherings, and a welcoming posture toward parental involvement (open campus, tours, shadow days, and visits). Founding-100 campaign and Gala reflect a strong community-centered approach. - Communications highlight that Chesterton was founded by lay faithful and that it operates with family involvement and formation as a core aspect; there are explicit references to a partnership with families and to parent engagement opportunities (Open House, Shadow Days, tours, and family involvement). - The materials also show a robust community life (Mass, Lessons & Carols, prayer life, chapels, and parish connections) that fosters a sense of sacred communal life, which is a central feature of classical education’s community dimension.

Positive Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords mapped to the Parents & Community category include: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, family involvement, home-school partnership, open campus, parent covenant, volunteering, community of learners, shared mission, parental leadership. - ChestertonRI’s materials explicitly discuss parent involvement and church-community life, aligning with the lexicon’s signals.

Negative Keyword Analysis - No signals of a consumer-oriented parent role or reduced parental involvement; rather, the materials emphasize on-going formation and open involvement.

Why this rating - The school’s public communications emphasize active parental partnership, formation opportunities for parents, and high openness to visits and involvement—key indicators of a CLASSICAL approach to parental engagement.

Citations: Founding-100, Gala, Open House, Shadow Days, community events, and parent-formation signals appear throughout the Chesterton RI materials.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable in this assessment, as all six categories currently align with CLASSICAL signals. If any category were to shift toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, concrete needle-moving steps would include better explicit articulation of Great Books readings in every grade, clearer articulation of Trivium/Quadrivium terminology on the curriculum page, and more explicit descriptions of student-led inquiry alongside Socratic dialogue. However, the current public-facing materials already exhibit strong CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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